

Muhammad Usman Naeem

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Education

Tufts University

Ph.D., Economics & Public Policy

Fields: Development; Environmental; Behavioural; Public

Medford, MA, USA

Expected 2027

Lahore University of Management Sciences

M.S., Economics

Lahore, Pakistan

2015

National University of Singapore

B.A., Economics

Singapore

2009

Research Positions

Harvard University, Department of Economics

Visiting Fellow

Cambridge, MA, USA

Jan–Jun 2026

International Growth Centre

Country Economist

Pakistan

2015–2021

References

Steve Cicala

steve.cicala@tufts.edu

Kyle Emerick

kyle.emerick@tufts.edu

Michael Greenstone

mgreenst@uchicago.edu

Frank Schilbach

fschilb@mit.edu

Job Market Paper

“The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Fails”

Abstract. Vehicle transport is a major source of air pollution, yet little is known about why drivers persist in behaviours that impose private costs and generate avoidable emissions. I study vehicle idling—leaving the engine running while stopped—as a repeated conservation decision with private and social benefits. With a telematics firm in Pakistan, I conduct a randomised field experiment with 6,621 private vehicles whose GPS trackers record ignition status, speed, and location every 10 seconds. The experiment separately varies private information, social information, payments, and a real-time in-car reminder. Baseline beliefs reveal widespread misperceptions about whether engines benefit from prolonged warm-up and when shutting off begins to save fuel or reduce environmental harm. Private information reduces daily idling from stops over 30 seconds by 1.8 minutes per vehicle-day, or 9% of the control mean. Social information and payments add little. By contrast, activating the real-time reminder increases idling by 1.0 minute relative to an identical no-reminder arm. The increase is concentrated in sustained idling spells: 81% arises beyond two minutes. Mechanism evidence indicates that drivers reduce preventive self-monitoring when they expect to rely on the device and delay corrective action after being reminded. The results identify private misperceptions as an important constraint on repeated conservation and show that externally supplied attention can crowd out rather than reinforce self-monitoring.

Working Papers

“Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing”

with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

“Preaching Against Power Theft”

with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

“Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement”

with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

Selected Work in Progress

“Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution”

with Steve Cicala and Kyle Emerick

“Making Pollution Visible: Emissions Disclosure”

with Michael Greenstone

Research Grants

Total funding as PI/Co-PI: over \$1.1 million.

£57,463 (IGC); \$13,972 (Weiss)	The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Fails
£277,762 (IGC)	Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing
\$167,904 (Weiss; K-CAI); £64,097 (IGC)	Preaching Against Power Theft
£124,677 (IGC); \$24,874 (Weiss)	Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement
£31,172 (IGC)	Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution
£66,272 (IGC)	Making Pollution Visible: Emissions Disclosure
\$109,938 (ATAI; DERF); £24,919 (IGC)	Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning

Presentations

2022–2026	Harvard University, Development Advising Group; IGC–World Bank ieConnect Transport Roundtable (planned); Stanford University, Behavioral Public Economics Boot Camp; UC Berkeley, Environmental and Energy Economics Summer School; MIT, Behavioral Economics; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop
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Teaching

Tufts University	Medford, MA, USA
Teaching Assistant, Advanced Empirical Methods for Doctoral Students	2026–2027
Teaching Assistant, Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory (undergraduate)	2025–2026
Teaching Assistant, Behavioral Economics (graduate)	2023–2026